

Respectful Language Guidelines

User story

As a dashboard user, I want the dashboard to use clear, respectful, and non-stigmatizing language so that children, families, communities, and public systems are described accurately and with dignity.

Purpose and main conclusion

This document completes the four tasks for the user story: reviewing KARA language standards, creating a preferred-language list, reviewing dashboard wording, and documenting final guidelines. The central rule is to describe the evidence precisely without turning a data point into a label about a child, family, community, or state. Public accountability can be direct without being demeaning.

Task 1 Review KARA Language Standards

The Fall 2026 project materials establish several language requirements even though they do not contain a separate KARA style guide. These project requirements form the working KARA standard for the dashboard:

- Use plain language for policymakers, advocates, journalists, and community members.
- Frame public findings as accountability and evidence, not punishment or blame.
- Do not treat a poor outcome number as automatic proof of structural failure. Explain what the measure shows and what additional evidence is needed.
- State when evidence is missing or Not Scorable. Never present missing data as zero.
- Treat racial and geographic disparity as a central analytic dimension while avoiding language that blames a population for inequitable conditions.
- Protect privacy. Do not display information that identifies a child or family.
- Use the official source term when accuracy requires it, but explain the term in plain language and distinguish allegations from findings.

These rules align with the CDC Health Equity Guiding Principles, which recommend person-first language, non-stigmatizing framing, avoidance of unintentional blame, community-aware terminology, active verbs, and accessible wording.

Task 2 Create Preferred Language List

Avoid or limit	Preferred wording	Reason
Foster kids	Children and youth in foster care	Places the person before the system status.
CPS kids or CPS families	Children and families involved with the child welfare system	Avoids defining people by agency involvement.
Abused child	Child reported to have experienced maltreatment; child with a substantiated maltreatment finding	Matches the evidence stage and avoids making an unverified allegation sound final.
Victim	Child who experienced harm, unless victim is the official legal or source term	Uses a neutral description while preserving legal accuracy when needed.
Perpetrator	Person alleged to have caused harm; person with a substantiated finding	Distinguishes allegation from completed finding.
Bad or negligent parents	Parent or caregiver named in a report; family with identified service or safety needs	Avoids moral labeling and states the documented condition.

Avoid or limit	Preferred wording	Reason
Broken family	Family experiencing specific safety, housing, health, or service-access challenges	Names the condition instead of stigmatizing the family.
At-risk children	Children experiencing a specified risk or barrier	Requires the dashboard to name the actual condition.
Troubled youth	Young person experiencing the stated challenge	Avoids a broad negative label.
Aged-out youth	Youth transitioning from foster care without permanent placement	Explains the event; use aging out only when it is the official metric label.
Former foster child	Young person or adult with lived experience of foster care	Uses person-centered language and recognizes lived experience.
Mentally ill children	Children with mental health conditions or behavioral health needs	Uses person-first, neutral terminology.
Minorities	Name the specific racial or ethnic group; use racially or ethnically minoritized groups when discussing structural conditions	Avoids treating diverse groups as one category.
Disproportionate group	Group that is overrepresented or underrepresented in the specified measure	States the direction and measure.
The state failed	The state did not meet the named framework criterion	Ties the conclusion to a documented standard.
Worst state	State with the greatest documented gaps under the framework	Keeps the accountability claim evidence-based and specific.
State hides data	Data was not publicly available as of the review date	Avoids assigning intent unless evidence supports that claim.
No data or 0	Data not available; not routinely collected; not publicly available; or not scorable	Uses the governed EIM availability status and prevents false zeros.
Directly comparable	Comparable	Matches the governed EIM comparability status.
Conditionally comparable	Partially Comparable	Matches the governed EIM comparability status and requires a qualification.

How to use official terminology

Some terms such as substantiated, alleged maltreater, victim, removal, or aging out may be required by a statute, dataset, or source. Keep the official term when it is needed to preserve the definition, then provide a short plain-language explanation. Do not silently replace a legal term if the replacement would change the meaning.

Task 3 Review Dashboard Wording

The following edits should be applied to dashboard titles, labels, tooltips, missing-data messages, and state summaries. The revised wording is short enough for the interface while still showing the evidence boundary.

Location	Do not use	Use instead	Required context
Chart title	Worst states for child protection	States with the greatest documented gaps	Add the framework version and review period in the subtitle.
Finding label	Abused children	Children with substantiated maltreatment findings	Use alleged reports when the metric is reports rather than findings.
System status	Failed state	Did not meet this framework criterion	Name the criterion in the tooltip.
Missing value	0 or blank	Data not available	Show the governed reason on hover.
Thin evidence	Score: 0	Not Scorable	Explain that Not Scorable is not zero or a failing grade.
Qualified comparison	State A is better than State B	This measure is Partially Comparable	Explain the definition, denominator, period, or geography difference.
Trend statement	Abuse increased 12%	Recorded reports increased 12% under the stated definition	Avoid claiming underlying incidence changed unless the evidence supports it.
Disparity statement	Group X is high risk	Group X is overrepresented in this measure	Include the reference population and rate.
Cause statement	Policy X caused improvement	The change followed Policy X; causal evidence was not established	Use causal wording only with validated causal evidence.
Public call-out	State X does not care about children	State X showed documented gaps in the following criteria	Describe institutional evidence, not motives.

Recommended reusable dashboard messages

Message title	Approved working text
Data not available	This source did not provide a usable value for the selected state, year, and metric.
Partially Comparable	This measure can be displayed for context, but important definition or reporting differences prevent a direct calculation.
Not Comparable	This value is excluded from comparative calculations because the definitions or reporting conditions differ materially.
Not Scorable	The available evidence does not support a defensible structural score. This status is not a zero.
Definition changed	The definition or collection method changed during this period. Interpret the trend with caution.
Outcome context	This outcome shows where further review may be needed. It does not by itself establish structural success or failure.
Privacy	Values are shown only at an approved aggregate level. No child or family is identified.

Task 4 Document Final Language Guidelines

1. Put people before system status, unless a community or person expresses a different preference.
2. Match every statement to the evidence stage: report, screened-in response, investigation, proposed finding, final finding, removal, placement, or outcome.

3. Describe the exact measure. Do not use reports, investigations, substantiations, victims, removals, entries, and children in care as interchangeable terms.
4. Describe institutional conditions and documented decisions, not motives or character.
5. Use neutral, active, plain language. Define necessary technical terms in tooltips or a glossary.
6. Use governed KARA/EIM labels for availability, comparability, and evidence confidence.
7. State the denominator, time period, geography, and important limitation near each comparison.
8. Do not imply causation from a trend or cross-state difference unless the evidence design supports causation.
9. Name racial and geographic inequities precisely and explain the structural context; do not blame affected communities.
10. Protect privacy and use approved aggregate reporting levels.
11. Review wording with people who have lived experience and with KARA's methodology lead when a term is contested or sensitive.
12. Revisit the list each semester because language, law, and community preferences change.

Final wording review checklist

Review area	Question
Evidence	Does each claim distinguish allegation, investigation, finding, and outcome?
People	Does the wording avoid defining a person by foster care, CPS, disability, justice, or housing status?
Comparison	Is the comparability label visible and consistent with the EIM record?
Missingness	Is the reason for missing data shown instead of a blank or zero?
Accountability	Does the text name the criterion and evidence rather than attacking people or assigning motives?
Equity	Does the statement identify the reference population and structural context?
Plain language	Can a non-technical reader understand the title, tooltip, and limitation?
Privacy	Could the wording or filter combination identify a child or family?
Approval	Was sponsor or methodology review requested for sensitive public claims?

Sources

- KARA: State-by-State CPS Policy Comparison and Awards Project Scope and Sprint 0 Direction, September 17, 2026
- KARA EIM: Field Inventory and Data Tracking README, Pick List Reference, Observation Data Schema, Rubric Variable Map, and Validation Lists, updated through September 30, 2026
- CDC: Health Equity Guiding Principles for Inclusive Communication - [source link](#)
- Minnesota DCYF: Child Protection and Child Welfare Data Dashboard - [source link](#)
- Child Welfare Information Gateway: Foster Care and Permanency resources - [source link](#)